DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Is Prophecy?

Daat Tevunot §175-180

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §175-180 (section 10, part 2) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 9 November 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

Page 600, section 10, part 2. Last time we discussed the holiness of time. Parts 2, 3 and 4 are about prophecy: part 2, what prophecy is; part 3, how God communicates it; part 4, the prophecy of Moshe. Part 5 is a new topic.

§175-177: a "bonus" question

The Neshamah says there is one more thing it would like to understand. It is not a big thing; unlike what we discussed until now, it will not trouble me if I do not know it. But I would still like to know. The Sekhel asks what it is. The Neshamah asks: what is prophecy, and how does it work?

§178: the definition

The Rabbi first asked the group to define prophecy. A message from Hashem? Information? The answer one participant gave was the right one: prophecy is connection to Hashem. Information is a by product. Sometimes a prophet learns things, and sometimes he is told to pass them on, but most prophets did not have messages for the people. The prophets of Tanakh whom we know were those who also had a message; there were many others.

The Sekhel defines it: prophecy is the knowledge and grasp of God's glory that the prophet attains.

But, the Ramhal stresses, not of God Himself. As he has said many times, the essence of God cannot be understood, even by the greatest prophet. We can only understand God through His actions, through how He relates to the world: sometimes rewarding, sometimes punishing, sometimes merciful, sometimes judging, giving life, healing. Those are descriptions of how He acts, not of what He is.

A prophet grasps a trait, and through it the future

God also shows the prophet how He sends forth His shefa and all its results. The Rabbi explained: if God shows a prophet His trait of healing, and the prophet grasps it at the highest

level, he understands all the ramifications of God's healing in the world, from the beginning of existence to the end.

That is why a prophet may know the future. People think a prophet is someone God tells "this will happen next year". It does not work like that. God reveals one of His traits; if you understand it fully, you understand all its implications, past and future, and so you know what may happen in a year, or five, or ten.

A participant objected that the real outcome depends on many traits interacting, so no prophet could be certain. The Rabbi agreed this explains why some prophecies did not come to pass: no prophet grasps all the traits fully.

§179-180: in images and riddles

The Neshamah asks for more. The Sekhel answers from explicit verses. "In a vision I make Myself known to him", "by the hand of the prophets I give images" (adammeh). Of Moshe alone it says "mouth to mouth… and not in riddles", which implies that with other prophets God does speak in riddles. Hazal say a dream is one sixtieth of prophecy: like a dream, ordinary prophecy is not understood straight away; it has to be unravelled.

The prophets do not experience the trait itself directly. The glory revealed to them takes shape in their minds as images, like garments, which carry the meaning, as with any parable.

Knowledge that is engraved

When we understand something, we talk it through, analyse and learn. Prophecy is not like that. The knowledge is engraved within the prophet; it becomes part of him. In many fields, even after careful analysis, you can be confident but never certain. A prophet has no doubt that it is God giving him these images. "It's impossible to have a prophet who's unsure whether he's with God or not."

He is given both the image and, as a separate piece of knowledge, its interpretation. The Ramhal cites the Rambam in the Laws of the Foundations of the Torah, who says the same: a prophecy is shown as a riddle, and the prophet is given its interpretation.

The Rabbi's first example: Yirmiyahu is shown an almond branch (makel shaked). The almond is the quickest fruit to blossom, and the message comes with it: the evil coming upon the nation will come quickly.

A participant asked why God uses riddles at all. Different prophets, said the Rabbi, receive images and interpretations according to their level; only Moshe received it directly. Prophecy was never a degree you earned once. You could be a prophet one day and lose it the next, and prophets kept training to reach higher levels.

Two kinds of image

Halfway down page 604, the Ramhal distinguishes images that teach God's traits from images that teach His actions, what He is going to do.

Images of traits. When God wants to show Himself as kind and generous, He appears as an old man, as in Daniel, "the Ancient of Days sat", with a long white beard. When He wants to

show strength and victory, He appears as a young warrior. At the Red Sea Israel saw Him as a strong young man, and at Sinai as an elder: the young go out to war, the old sit and teach.

Images of actions. The Ramhal lists several:

- Yirmiyahu's almond branch: the evil will come quickly.
- Yirmiyahu's boiling pot, bubbling most from its northern side: the enemy will come from the north.
- Yaakov's ladder, with angels going up and down: you will be protected.
- Yehezkel's open scroll, written clearly: the suffering to come will be open for all to see.
- Zekharyah's measure (eifah): everything will be repaid precisely. And his golden menorah: things will be good again. The Rabbi asked where we know the menorah of Zekharyah from: one of only two haftarot read twice a year, on Parashat Behaalotekha and on Shabbat Hanukkah.

Why traits come with their meaning

The Ramhal says that with images of God's traits, the prophet understands the meaning immediately. With images of future actions, sometimes he does not: Zekharyah had to ask what he was being shown.

Why the difference? Because misunderstanding God's traits is too dangerous; a mistake there could lead to heresy. A mistake about events is less grave.

Contradictory images

The last paragraph says a prophet may see several images at once, even contradictory ones. Hazal read "face to face (panim befanim) Hashem spoke with you": "panim" is plural, twice, so four faces. The Rabbi gave Hazal's teaching: one face for teaching Scripture, a plain, even face for Mishnah, a joyful face for Talmud, and an interpretive face for aggadah. And yet "I am Hashem your God", one God, because these are all images.

He compared it to two commands said "in one utterance": the prohibition of marrying a brother's wife and the misvah of yibbum, or "Zakhor" and "Shamor" of Shabbat. What seem contradictory work together. Since the images are not independent things but revelations God creates, He can give as many as He wishes; and none is in vain, since each teaches one of His traits.

Summary

- Prophecy is connection to God and a grasp of His glory; information is its by product.
- No prophet grasps God's essence, only His traits; fully grasping a trait reveals its consequences, including the future.
- Prophecy comes through images and riddles, and the prophet's knowledge is engraved, without doubt; only Moshe received it without riddles.
- Images teach either God's traits (old man, young warrior) or His actions (almond branch, boiling pot, ladder, scroll, menorah); trait images always come with their meaning, because error there leads to heresy.

- A prophet may see contradictory images at once, because they are images God creates, not God Himself.

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